

R3 Reflection Buddy System

Pillar	Reflection	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	20 minutes (setup), then 10 minutes weekly	Group Size	Pairs
Mode	Paired practice	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	R1 active (so there's something to discuss)	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Discomfort sharing reflections openly, reflection practice dying after initial enthusiasm, need for low-stakes accountability

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Processing reflection with another person activates social cognition circuits that solo reflection does not reach. The act of articulating an insight to someone else forces the brain to organise and clarify the thought (a process called the generation effect). The listener's response provides a mirror that can deepen or redirect the reflection.

The buddy system also provides the social accountability that sustains habits. The brain treats a commitment to another person differently than a commitment to oneself: social commitments activate the anterior cingulate cortex (which monitors goal-relevant behaviour) more strongly than private commitments.

The Exercise

Phase 1: Pairing (5 minutes)

Pair team members. Matching criteria: trust (they need to be honest with each other), different enough to offer fresh perspective, similar enough in schedule to actually meet. Avoid pairing direct reports with their manager.

Phase 2: Structure Design (10 minutes)

Each pair agrees on:

- When: a specific weekly time (15 minutes max, calendared)
- Where: in person, video call, or even a walking conversation
- What: each person shares one reflection from the week (an insight, a pattern, a question) and one action they're taking or want to take

CONVERSATION STRUCTURE

Person A: "Here's what I noticed this week..." (2 minutes)

Person B asks one question (not advice, not their own experience, a question): "What do you think is behind that?" or "What would you do differently?" (1 minute)

Switch roles.

Close: each person names one thing they'll pay attention to next week. (1 minute each)

Phase 3: Confidentiality Agreement (5 minutes)**WHAT TO SAY**

"What you discuss with your buddy stays between you. If something surfaces that needs team-level attention, the person who raised it decides whether and how to bring it to the group. The buddy does not share, summarise, or reference it without explicit permission."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Buddy conversations become chat sessions rather than reflection	Provide the conversation structure on a card. If pairs drift, the structure brings them back. It's not about having a nice conversation. It's about processing reflection with another person.
One person dominates the buddy time	The timed structure prevents this. "Two minutes each for sharing, one minute each for questions. Use a timer if needed."
Pairs stop meeting after 3-4 weeks	Calendar the sessions for 8 weeks at the outset. If they're not calendared, they won't happen. After 8 weeks, check in: "Is this adding value?" If yes, continue. If not, try different pairings or adjust the format.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
R1: Micro-Reflection	R3 provides the social processing layer for R1's individual reflections.	R1 feeds into R3
R2: From Ideas to Action	Buddies can serve as the accountability partners for R2's implementation intentions.	R3 supports R2
L6: Accountability in Learning	Same pairing mechanism. Teams can combine reflection and learning accountability in one buddy relationship.	Complementary